

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

STATE OF THE STATE ADDRESS

Pritzker’s budget a belt-tightener

\$55.2 billion plan calls for no new taxes and keeps state spending mostly flat; governor uses stage to issue warning on Trump, drawing parallels to Nazism

By Rick Pearson, Jeremy Gorner, Olivia Olander, Addison Wright and Dan Petrella | Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — While Gov. JB Pritzker delivered a no-new-taxes, belt-tightening spending proposal for Illinois on Wednesday, the prospective presidential contender spoke to a larger, national audience by likening the actions of President Donald Trump and his followers to the rise of Nazism in 1930s Germany.

Painting a brighter picture of the state’s finances than his administration had last year, when a \$3.2 billion budget hole was said to loom, Pritzker’s \$55.2

billion plan for the year beginning July 1 includes required funding increases for schools and pension contributions. But the proposal keeps spending flat in most other areas, including programs favored by the second-term Democrat and his allies in the General Assembly.

The governor also rolled out a series of policy proposals not tied to the budget, including efforts to reduce prescription drug costs and limit students’ use of cellphones during the school day.

But Pritzker, a frequent Trump

critic who’s yet to say whether he’ll seek a third term in 2026, spent a substantial portion of his roughly 35-minute speech in the Illinois House chamber criticizing the White House’s early fiscal and economic maneuvers and drawing parallels to the rapid rise of Germany’s Third Reich. He also called out both Republicans and fellow Democrats who go along with or appease Trump.

“My oath is to the Constitution

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Gov. JB Pritzker walks the floor before delivering his budget address at the state Capitol on Wednesday. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Nicholas Trutenko hugs his son, Joey, after being acquitted on all charges by Lake County Judge Daniel Shanes at the courthouse in Rolling Meadows on Wednesday. Andrew Horvat, right, was also acquitted. Both men are former Cook County prosecutors. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Ex-assistant state’s attorneys acquitted in uncommon trial

‘Extraordinary’ case sought to hold lawyers accountable for wrongful conviction

By Madeline Buckley and Christy Gutowski
Chicago Tribune

Two former Cook County assistant state’s attorneys on Wednesday were acquitted of multiple felony counts following an unusual criminal trial connected to an infamous Chicago wrongful conviction case surrounding the 1982 killings of

two on-duty police officers.

Dealing a blow to special prosecutors who spent years investigating and trying the case, Judge Daniel Shanes found Nicholas Trutenko, 69, and Andrew Horvat, 49, not guilty after a bench trial that was halted for nearly a year due to a mid-trial appeal.

The special prosecutors sought to achieve a rare feat in holding government lawyers account-

able for alleged misconduct in a wrongful convictions case, which have become increasingly prevalent in Chicago in recent years. But Shanes, a Lake County judge who heard the case in lieu of the recused Cook County judiciary, ruled the special prosecution team fell far short of meeting its burden.

“Everything about this case is unprecedented and extraordi-

nary,” Shanes said from the bench at a branch court in Rolling Meadows. “At the same time, it is like any and every criminal case in America.”

After the verdict, a smiling Trutenko hugged his son and lawyers, James McKay and Brian Sexton, as other supporters gathered. On the other side of the

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US, Ukraine relations swiftly souring as Trump turns on ally

By Hanna Arhirova and Justin Spike
Associated Press

KYIV, Ukraine — Relations between Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and President Donald Trump deteriorated rapidly Wednesday as Zelenskyy said Trump was living in a Russian-made “disinformation space” and Trump called Zelen-

skyy “a dictator without elections” in comments that were sure to complicate efforts to end the war.

Zelenskyy also said he would like Trump’s team “to be more truthful” as he offered his first response to a series of striking claims that Trump made a day earlier, including falsely suggesting that Kyiv was to blame for Russia’s war, entering its fourth year next week.

The comments were a staggering back-and-forth between leaders of two countries that have been staunch allies in recent years under Trump’s predecessor. While President Joe Biden was in the White House, the U.S. provided crucial military equipment to Kyiv to fend off the invasion and used its political weight

Turn to Ukraine, Page 4

APPEAL TO PROFITS:

The Russian government’s top investment manager brought a simple message to Tuesday’s talks with the Trump administration: By pulling out of Russia in outrage over the invasion of Ukraine, American companies had walked away from piles of cash. **Nation & World**

Filing: Jones asked for \$5K

New details emerge in the state senator’s federal bribery case

By Jason Meisner and Ray Long
Chicago Tribune

State Sen. Emil Jones III was dining at a downtown Chicago steakhouse with a clout-heavy red-light camera company executive in the summer of 2019 when the executive expressed concern about Jones’ pending bill requiring a study on the ubiquitous and publicly maligned automated traffic systems.

The executive, Omar Maani of SafeSpeed LLC, then asked Jones a point-blank question: How much do you want?

“You can raise me five grand. That’d be good,” Jones, a Chicago Democrat, allegedly told Maani over that July 17, 2019, dinner at Steak 48, according to a prosecution court filing late Tuesday. Jones also told Maani it would be nice if he could secure a part-time job for his legislative intern.

Maani, who was secretly recording the meeting for the FBI, told Jones that he needed to think of a “creative way” to get the money to him. “We have reporting requirements and everything and I just don’t want to go down that path,” Maani said, according to prosecutors.

“I get it,” Jones allegedly replied.

That conversation and other key details were revealed for the first time as Jones’ April 7 trial date on bribery charges fast approaches.

Though Jones’ trial is set, prosecutors told U.S. District Judge Andrea Wood last month that there had been recent discussions about a potential guilty plea.

But Jones’ attorney, Victor Henderson, shot down any notion of a deal in a statement to the Tribune on Wednesday.

“There has been no suggestion by the Senator that he intends to plead guilty,” Henderson wrote. “As his lawyers, we have engaged in the typical listen and talk sessions with

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IG underscores water main risk

Scores of water mains throughout Chicago are too close to sewer lines, according to a new report that cautions the potential risks to public health. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Johnson’s bond proposal stalls

A bond plan defended by the mayor as “relatively typical” was held up in the council Wednesday amid aldermanic concerns about Chicago’s debt. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Endeavor settles more lawsuits

Endeavor Health has settled the last batch of pending lawsuits filed by patients who allege they were sexually abused by a former obstetrician/gynecologist. **Business**